YOUR MAGAZINE FROM GALLIONS

thamesview

NEWS • EVENTS • COMPETITIONS

FEBRUARY 2013
www.gallionsha.co.uk



WE HAVE OFFICIALLY MOVED

WELFARE BENEFITS CHANGES - ARE YOU READY?

FREE CHARLTON TICKETS UP FOR GRABS!

Gallions Housing Association

CONTENTS

04 BLOCK INSPECTIONS

05 INTERVIEW WITH MANDY DOE

10 HELP US TO HELP YOU

12 WELFARE BENEFITS CHANGES

16 TENANTS VIEW

19 YOU SAID... WE DID...

22 HOUSEMARK RESULTS

24 NEW CAFE IN TOWN

WELCOME

We hope that you all had a safe and happy holiday season and that you're sticking to those news years resolutions. 2012 was an exciting year with the Diamond Jubilee and the Olympics, and now it's time to carry on that excitement and motivation into 2013.

This year there will be many changes for our residents. Welfare Reforms' first set of changes are due in April and I would encourage anyone who thinks that the changes may affect them to seek help now. You can read about our programmes to help prepare for welfare reform; such as: employment programmes, debt management and through our benefits advice team (on page 12 and 13). If last summer's events taught us anything it is that when we take the initiative and plan, there will almost always be a good outcome.

Lastly, I want to take the opportunity to thank Anita Glover who edited Thamesview magazine for several years. She was a great asset to the magazine and Gallions, we wish her well in her new role.

CONTACT US - 0300 123 1237

For those residents who are hearing impaired we offer the Typetalk service.

Write to us: PO BOX 268, Sidcup, DA15 0FB
Visit us: 15 Joyce Dawson Way, London, SE28 8RA
Customer Contact Team: 0300 123 1237
Repairs Contact Team: 0300 123 1238
Text Relay: 18001

EDITOR
Aisha Vance • 0300 123 1237
thamesview@gallionsha.co.uk

RESIDENT EDITORS
Michael Pavis, Dave Rugg, Chris Ash, Cherry Kent, Con Lobo, George Ameyaw and Stan Rider

Mixed Sources
Product group from well-managed forests and other controlled sources
www.fsc.org Cert no. SGS-COC-003351
© 1996 Forest Stewardship Council
FSC

Gallions Residents Group

Gallions Housing Association

We have officially moved into our new office

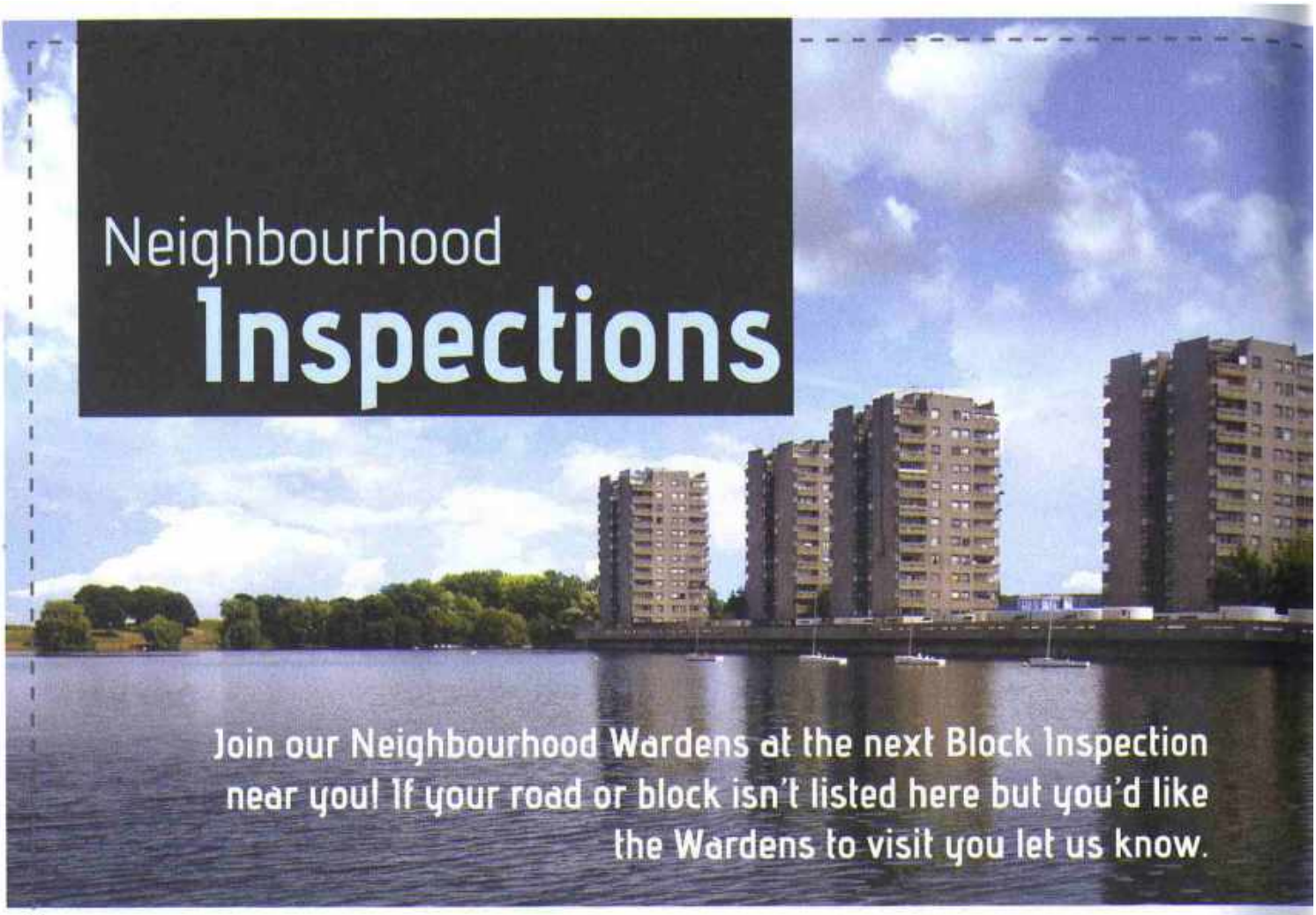


We have now moved our resident office from Titmuss Avenue to 15 Joyce Dawson Way, SE28; right in the heart of Thamesmead Town Centre. The new office has private interview rooms, a self serve kiosk and two public computers to pay your rent and carry out various tasks online. Do drop by and say hello, but if you can't, you can still access a lot of our services from the comfort of your own home by logging onto www.gallionsha.co.uk

THE OFFICE HOURS ARE:

Monday, Tuesday, Thursday and Friday from 9am-5pm and Wednesday from 9am-6pm

Neighbourhood Inspections



Join our Neighbourhood Wardens at the next Block Inspection near you! If your road or block isn't listed here but you'd like the Wardens to visit you let us know.

WATERFIELD

Neighbourhood Services Officer Greg Smikle - Warden Phil Briggs
Meet at junction between Byron Close and Owen Close at 2pm
20 February 2013
10 April 2013

MOORINGS

Neighbourhood Services Officer Greg Smikle - Warden Phil Briggs
Meet at the junction between Titmuss Avenue and Booth Close at 2pm
15 February 2013
5 April 2013

MANORWAY

Neighbourhood Services Officer Greg Smikle - Warden Phil Briggs
Meet at the junction between Goldcrest Close and Whimbrel Close at 2pm
5 March 2013

CROSSWAYS

Neighbourhood Services Officer Larry Lidbury - Warden Chris Waite
Contact us if you would like to attend and we will agree a meeting place - 2pm
3 April 2013

BROADWATERS

Neighbourhood Services Officer Larry Lidbury - Warden Chris Waite
Meet at the junction between Whinchat Road and Wigeon Path at 2pm
28 February 2013
16 April 2013

SIDCUP & ORPINGTON

Neighbourhood Services Officer Larry Lidbury
Contact us if you would like to attend and we will agree a meeting place - 2pm
10 April 2013

PARKVIEW

Neighbourhood Services Officer Davinder Bal - Warden Frank Smith
To meet outside Jacob House at 1.30pm
25th April 2013

GREENMEAD

Neighbourhood Services Officer Davinder Bal - Warden Frank Smith
To meet outside the post office in Lime Row at 3pm
25th April 2013

OLD CHURCH COURT- NORTHEND ROAD & BALTIMORE CLOSE

Neighbourhood Services Officer Davinder Bal - Warden Frank Smith
For Old Church Court meet by the entry gate to the car park at 2pm
For North End Road and Baltimore close telephone us if you would like to attend and we will agree a meeting place
21st February 2013

SOUTHMERE

2pm at the corner of Seacourt Drive and Hartslock Drive
Neighbourhood Services Officer: Nathaniel Takyi-Berko & Neighbourhood Services Warden: Stephen Hayzen
17th April 2013

LESNES

2pm outside of Radley House (Opposite the ball court)
Neighbourhood Services Officer: Nathaniel Takyi-Berko & Neighbourhood Services Warden: Stephen Hayzen
18th April 2013

ST. JOSEPH'S COURT

2pm outside of 11-16 St. Joseph's Court
Neighbourhood Services Officer: Nathaniel Takyi-Berko & Neighbourhood Services Warden: Stephen Hayzen
25th April 2013

TOWNHALL SQUARE:

2pm outside of Crayford Library and Community centre
Neighbourhood Services Officer: Nathaniel Takyi-Berko & Neighbourhood Services Warden: Stephen Hayzen
24th April 2013

LITTLE ILFORD

Neighbourhood Services Officer Aaron Nicholson – Warden Chris Waite
Meet outside the main entrance to McLagan House at 10am
7 February 2013

BARRIER PARK

Neighbourhood Services Officer Aaron Nicholson – Warden Chris Waite
Meet outside the main entrance to Estuary House at 1pm
7 February 2013

PHOENIX WORKS

Forrest Hill
Neighbourhood Services Officer Aaron Nicholson – Warden Chris Waite
Meet outside the main entrance to Phoenix Works at 10am
21 February 2013

LEWISHAM

Neighbourhood Services Officer Aaron Nicholson – Warden Chris Waite
Meet inside the main entrance to 117 Lewisham Way at 11am
21 February 2013

MILLHARBOUR

Neighbourhood Services Officer Aaron Nicholson – Warden Chris Waite
Meet inside the main entrance to Millharbour at 10:30am
22 February 2013

CARNELL APARTMENTS

Neighbourhood Services Officer Aaron Nicholson – Warden Chris Waite
Meet inside the main entrance to Carnell Apartments at 12:30pm
22 February 2013

GLOSTER RIDLEY COURT

Neighbourhood Services Officer Aaron Nicholson – Warden Chris Waite
Meet in the courtyard of Gloster Ridley Court at 1:00pm
22 February 2013

LIMEHOUSE BASIN

Neighbourhood Services Officer Aaron Nicholson – Warden Chris Waite
Meet in the courtyard of John Nash Mews at 1:45pm
22 February 2013

CARMINE WHARF

Neighbourhood Services Officer Aaron Nicholson – Warden Chris Waite
Meet inside the main entrance to Carmine Wharf at 2:15pm
22 February 2013

Halloween Party held at The Link... a success



Gallions Housing Association and Trust Thamesmead put on a Halloween party at the Link on Friday 2 November. Over 100 children and parents enjoyed the free event, which included snacks, games and a dj.

Quotes from parents:

"It's a great event for the kids. There's a big age range of activities to do and it's a safe environment for the kids." - Clare, Mum

'Fun for the kids and it really brings the community together, especially something that allows everyone to meet each other. The fact that it's free and gives the kids something to do is also very positive.' - Toni Bird, Mum

'I think it's a good idea to have events like this. I'd like to see more - it's a really good idea.' - Franklin, Dad

Why you may consider becoming a member of the Thamesview Residents' Panel

Have you ever read Thamesview and thought - that's a great article, but what about... ?

Thamesview Magazine is a historic source of information for Gallions' residents. The magazine has been distributed for over five years and we've seen numerous residents contributing to the magazine. Currently, we have seven active members of the Thamesview Residents' Panel, but we are currently seeking more members to suggest articles, look at past content and help us to make the magazine even better.

What does the resident panel do? Some of the tasks are:

- To help the editor come up with relevant articles.
- Look at previous editions, and suggest recommendations.
- Write articles for the magazine.
- Attend meetings and discuss and decide next issues content.
- Suggest articles that will help develop the relationship between Gallions and residents.
- Proof reading.
- It's fun!

You do not have to take part in all of these tasks, meaning you take on what you think you can handle. If you're interested please email communications@gallionsha.co.uk or call 0208 308 4080 and ask to speak to a member of the communications team.



Interview with

MANDY DOE

Director of Neighbourhoods

Q: How long have you been with Gallions?

A: I've been with Gallions for two years. I'm the director of neighbourhoods and I'm responsible for tenancy and leasehold management and our Team Gallions service – which provides all of our caretaking and cleaning and maintenance of our greenspaces including parks and lakes. In fact, when I first started I spent a very cold day out with Team Gallions picking up litter and cutting bushes in Birchmere Park ! I also work closely with Trust Thamesmead to work on projects to help improve the quality of life for our residents including help with getting into employment and training and community development.

Q: How long have you been in social housing?

A: Over 30 years and its flown by. It's a great job and every day is really interesting. It's a job where you can make a difference as where people live is so important to their lives. As a social landlord, one of our aims is to help our residents who are vulnerable or going through difficult times and we try to put a lot of thought into the social side as well as being a landlord.

Q: What do you think some of the key issues residents have, and how is Gallions going to tackle this?

A: There are huge changes to welfare benefits happening and over 50 % of our residents receive help with their rent - I think it will have a major impact on our residents and this will be a key issue when the changes come into effect from April this year. Gallions is trying to get residents to prepare for these changes now and to take up the services we provide around benefit advice and employment and training programmes run with Trust Thamesmead. These programmes will help support residents get into work and in turn help them pay their rent. If you need advice please call 0208 308 4080 and ask to speak to a member of our benefits advice team.

Q: What would you say to residents who may want their voices to be heard or want to get more involved?

A: We are always looking for more residents to get involved. We have a whole range of groups they can join, making a difference while meeting new people. they should ring the Resident Engagement Team on 0208 308 4080 to see what groups there are and what they might be interested in, or they can contact Trust Thamesmead for other community projects. We're fortunate to have great facilities coming into Thamesmead like The Link for people to use to help facilitate community groups and involvement.

MY HOME ONLINE HAS CHANGED



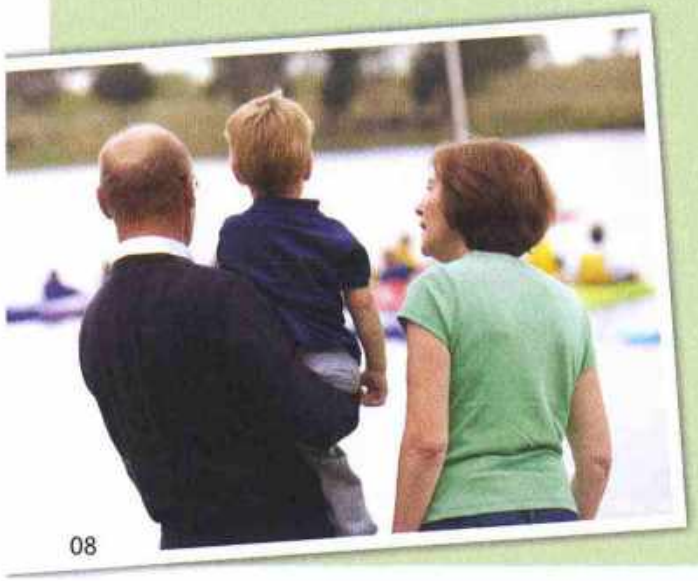
My Home Online is a great service that gives you secure access to your housing information online, 24 hours a day. You can use the system to view your rent account statement, any repairs you have reported and any transfer application details.

We have given our online payment and account management facility a makeover. If you're an existing user with a login, you will need to re-register via our website. New users will have to get an account set up.

The improved facility will still allow you to make payments, provide real-time information on your rent or service charge account and give you live information on the status of any repairs reported. You will also be able to see details of your active housing transfer applications and be able to update your personal details.

Register now and enjoy the benefits of this great facility; visit www.gallionsha.co.uk

CELEBRATING EQUALITY AND DIVERSITY



What was formally called 'Thamesmead Talks', which was a disability forum is currently undergoing a change. We want residents to get involved in creating the aims and objectives of the group, the main purpose - promoting and celebrating diversity within the community will be the inspiration for creating the purpose.

It will not only be for residents who classify themselves as having a disability, but for those that feel passionate about diversity and equal opportunities and want to make a difference in their local community.

If you want to find out more information, please get in touch with Helen Chambers t: 0208 308 4080 e: hchambers@gallionsha.co.uk

TENANTS RECIPE...

BEETROOT CAKE WITH ORANGE FROSTING



Ingredients

For the Cake

3 medium raw beetroot
200g (7oz) plain flour
¾tsp baking powder
¾tsp bicarbonate of soda
¾tsp ground cinnamon
¼tsp fine salt
50g (2oz) soft dark brown sugar
125g (4½oz) light muscovado sugar
3 large eggs
½tsp vanilla extract
300ml (½pt) vegetable oil
zest ½ orange

For the icing

50g (2oz) unsalted butter, softened
100g (4oz) icing sugar, sifted
zest ½ orange
125g (4½oz) cream cheese
orange zest, for decorating

Preparation

Preheat the oven to 180 C, 160 C fan, 350 F, gas 4. Line a 900g (2lb) loaf tin with baking paper.

1. Put the peeled beetroot into a food processor and process for a few seconds.

2. Add the other ingredients to the bowl and process until a soft batter is formed.

3. Pour the mixture into the prepared tin and bake on the middle shelf for 40 minutes. Turn the oven down to 170 C, 150 C fan, 325 F, gas 3 and bake for a further 20 minutes or until a skewer comes out clean when inserted into the middle of the cake. Leave to cool for 10 minutes and then remove from the tin and cool on a wire rack.

4. To make the icing, beat together the butter, icing sugar and orange zest until smooth and creamy. Add the cream cheese and beat again until smooth. Spread the icing over the top of the cake and decorate with orange zest.



DEBT ADVICE BEATING THOSE JANUARY BIG BILL BLUES

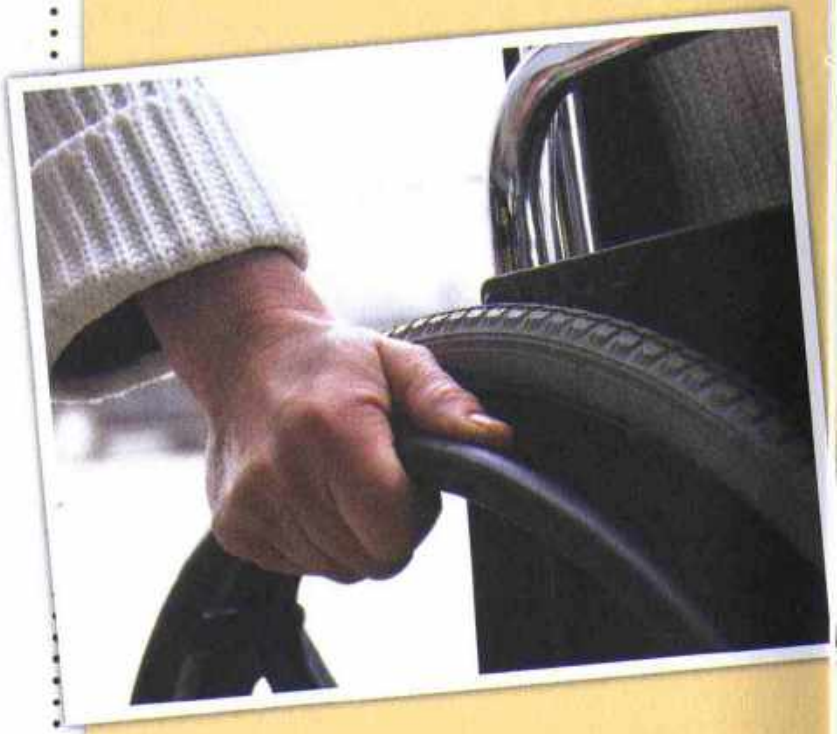
There's no way round it - for most of us, January is the month of big bills. Gas and electricity bills are high because the heating has been on for at least three months (and there's a price increase on the way). And then there are the credit cards. And the store cards. And the overdraft. And the catalogue payments. And the payday loan...

If you are struggling with your debts, contact a free, independent debt advice charity such as Debt Advice Foundation. Their helpline is 0800 043 40 50, or you can go to www.debtadvicefoundation.org

NEW TENANTS' HANDBOOK AVAILABLE

A new edition of the tenants' handbook is available online on our website at www.gallionsha.co.uk under 'publications'. If you would like to receive a copy via post, please contact our communications team t: 0208 308 4080 or e: communications@gallionsha.co.uk

HELP US TO HELP YOU



Gallions wants to provide the best service we can to our residents, but sometimes we need a little help from you.

For example, if you tell us that you have a mobility issue we can make sure that our staff and contractors will wait a little longer than normal after knocking on your door; or if you have difficulty understanding forms or letters can we can arrange to visit and talk to you.

If you have a disability or a special need please let us know. Help us to help you! Please contact Helen Chambers for more information: 0208 308 4080

HAVING YOUR BOILER REGULARLY CHECKED IS IMPORTANT!



By law Gallions must make sure that the gas appliances within their tenanted properties is properly checked every 12 months. If you are a tenant you will receive a letter from our contractor, P & R, to let you know the date they will service your boiler.

This appointment must be kept. If your boiler has not been serviced in 12 months and you have not received a letter please contact our customer services team on 0208 308 4080 and let them know.

Please remember to double check your appointment to ensure you will be available on the day of your servicing appointment.Wasted calls for both servicing and repairs carried out by the contractor are approximately 250 per month.

This means that the contractor is then not able to attend urgent calls as his time is being wasted unnecessarily. Tenants who are found to be wasting the time of the contractor will possibly be recharged.

It is extremely important to have your boiler serviced once a year. If your boiler is not working correctly, it could lead to potential Carbon Monoxide (CO) poisoning that could cause serious harm, or even death.

Approximately 15 deaths per year are caused through gas appliances which have not been checked or serviced.

There are signs that you can look out for that indicate there may be a problem with your boiler:

Yellow or orange rather than blue flames (except fuel effect fires or flueless appliances which display this colour flame) Soot or yellow/brown staining around or on appliances Pilot lights that frequently blow out

Early symptoms of carbon monoxide (CO) poisoning can mimic many common ailments and may easily be confused with food poisoning, viral infections, flu or simple tiredness. Symptoms to look out for include:

- headaches or dizziness
- breathlessness
- nausea
- loss of consciousness
- tiredness
- pains in the chest or stomach
- erratic behaviour
- visual problems

If you or your family experience any of the above symptoms and believe you may have been exposed to carbon monoxide, you should seek urgent medical advice from either your GP or an A&E department.



Major changes to the welfare benefits system are just around the corner. From April 2013, many residents will see their benefits:

Capped

The government will add up all the benefits you're allowed and make sure that the total you get in your hand every week does not go above either £350 or £500 – depending on circumstances.

Reductions

If you have more bedrooms than the government says you need (there are strict rules around that) you will lose some housing benefit. Under the new rules, if you have one spare bedroom, your housing benefit will be cut by 14%, and if you have two or more spare bedrooms, it will be reduced by 25%.

Here is an example of how this will work. John lives alone in a two bedroom flat costing £80 per week. At the moment housing benefit covers all his rent. Under the new rules, he will be seen as having an extra bedroom so will lose 14% of his housing benefit reducing it to £68.80 per week (14% of £80 is £11.20; £80 - £11.20 = £68.80). John will have to make up the shortfall of £11.20 per week.

There are further changes ahead, including the introduction of Personal Independence Payments (which will replace Disability Living Allowance) and Universal Credits later on in the year.

We'll continue to provide more information about all these changes as they emerge.

What to do now

If you believe that you have a spare bedroom and could be affected (by what is called the under-occupancy rules) then you need to consider downsizing or looking at ways in which you could make up the shortfall. The benefits cap could also severely deplete household income so you might want to look at ways of managing this by budgeting.

Help is available

If you need help with budgeting or financial management, there are a number of agencies out there that you can turn to.

Please avoid the temptation to borrow money from unscrupulous lenders at extremely high interest rates. Below are a number of agencies that can offer general help and advice about debt management:

Fair Finance: 020 8988 0627

National Debt Advice: 0808 808 4000

You can also contact our Welfare Benefits Team on 0300 123 1237. We can check your entitlement to benefits and make sure your household is claiming everything that it is entitled to. We can also discuss alternative housing options and help you access employment advice/training.

"Not everyone on benefits will be affected, some will be exempt. Further changes could still be made to the system affecting the accuracy of the advice given at a particular moment in time."

We'll be at the following places in February:

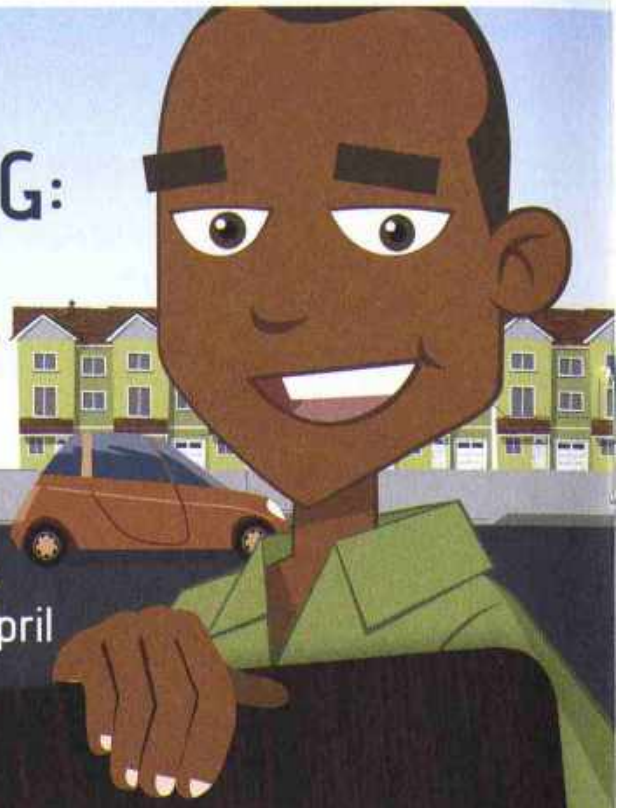
When	Where
Monday 18th Feb, 10am – 4pm	**Emmanuel Baptist Church, Yarnton Way, Erith DA18 4DR**
Tuesday 19th Feb, 10am – 4pm	Outside Gallions' office at 15 Joyce Dawson Way, London SE28 8RA
Wednesday 20th Feb, 10am – 4pm	**Manor Close Community Centre I 40 Manor Close I Thamesmead I SE28 8EY**
Thursday 21st Feb, 10am – 4pm	Broadwater Village Hall I 1c Goosander Way, West Thamesmead, SE28 0ER
Friday 22nd Feb, 10am – 4pm	**The Link, Belvedere Road, London SE28**

Useful contacts

Gallions' Welfare Benefits Team **T: 0300 123 1237**
The government's information line **T: 0845 605 7064**
Citizen's Advice Bureau: **www.citizensadvice.org.uk**

WELFARE BENEFITS CHANGES ARE COMING:

ARE YOU READY?



Join us at one of our **FREE** welfare benefits road shows to find out how changes from April this year may affect you.

WE'LL BE AT THE FOLLOWING PLACES IN FEBRUARY:

Mon 18th Feb 10am - 4pm	Emmanuel Baptist Church Yarnton Way, Erith, DA18 4DR
Tue 19th Feb 10am - 4pm	Outside Gallions' office at 15 Joyce Dawson Way, London, SE28 8RA
Wed 20th Feb 10am - 4pm	Manor Close Community Centre 40 Manor Close, Thamesmead, SE28 8EY
Thurs 21st Feb 10am - 4pm	Broadwater Village Hall 1c Goosander Way, West Thamesmead, SE28 0ER
Fri 22nd Feb 10am – 4pm	The Link Belvedere Road, London, SE2 9BS

WIN £100*

GRAND FINALE; FRIDAY 22ND

SPECIAL TREATS FOR ONE DAY ONLY.

Come along and

- be in with a chance of winning £100*
- grab a free hand massage
- talk to other providers about getting back into work, money matters and much more.

Lots of fun activities for the kids too.

For more information, tel. 0300 123 1237

TRUST. THAMESMEAD

Gallions Housing Association

*Competition open to Gallions Housing Association residents only.

GALLIONS SYSTEM FOR COMPLAINTS

Gallions takes residents' comments about our services very seriously. We see this as away of using residents' comments to make improvements in the way we deliver our services.

There are lots of ways for you to comment on the services:-

By telephone:
0208 308 4080

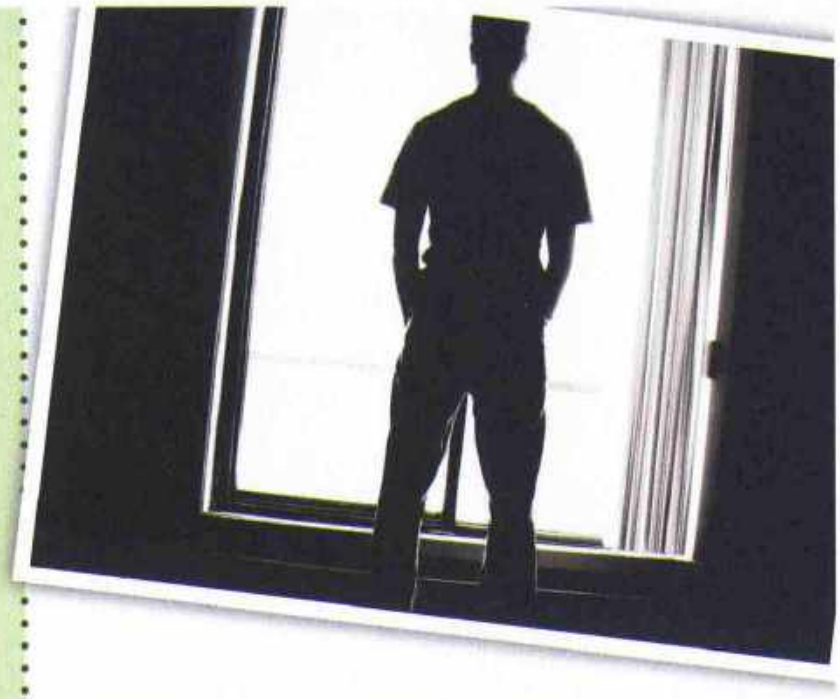
By email:
Complaints@gallionsha.co.uk

Through the website:
www.gallionsha.co.uk

By letter:
PO Box 268 DA15 0FB

All of our residents can use our complaints service.

This includes social tenants, lease holders, free holders and affordable rent tenants.



TENANCY FRAUD

We would like to thank all residents that have contacted us with their suspicions of tenancy fraud and sub letting.

We recovered possession of 40 homes in 2012. These have now been let those in need of social housing. This would not have been possible without your help.

As part of our investigations we liaise with police and benefit fraud officers along with other agencies. One of the cases that we investigated led to the arrest of a tenant, who was later convicted of fraud, as they had not disclosed that they owned a home. They were investigated by the financial intelligence unit at Greenwich Police and along with the conviction for fraud were ordered to pay over £10,000 for the profit they had made as a result of this fraudulent behaviour.

Another resident was found to be sub letting our property and fraudulently claiming state benefits. Once he became aware of our investigation he fled the property and is currently wanted for benefit fraud.

Should you have any suspicions about the way one of our homes is being used then please contact us confidentially either on 0300 123 1237 or via our website.

Resident Auditors

Our resident audit team have now completed and passed with flying colours the second phase of their training with Housing Quality Network.

So far they have looked at Team Gallions environmental services and as a result of this and the Gallions Residents' Group scrutiny Gallions have:

- Published a leaflet setting out clearly what repairs residents are responsible for and what Gallions will do. This was sent out with copies of July's Thamesview
- Changed the way we look at complaints
- Began one to one meeting with all Team Gallions operatives to manage performance better
- Reviewed Team Gallions service standards in consultation with residents
- More changes are in the pipeline...

Audits take place over 3 or 4 weeks taking 5/6 full days. Each auditor receives £100 in vouchers following each audit.

We are looking to recruit more auditors and will be holding a taster day in March. If you would like to learn new skills, brush up on old ones and help us improve the services that we provide to all residents please call Helen Chambers on 020 8308 4098 hchambers@gallionsha.co.uk

Residents vote on Colour Coralline artist!

Residents from Coralline Walk were asked to vote on three artists' designs that will be painted on the side of the building (facing onto Harrow Manorway). The artist chosen was Steve Wilson with 49.3 % of the vote.

Colour Coralline is a flagship project funded through a partnership of Ground work London and the Dulux Let's Colour campaign, which uses colour to transform local neighbourhoods.

Keep a lookout for the painting dates!



Tenants view...



Gallions Residents Group (GRG)

GRG the resident scrutiny panel recruited new members over the summer and now have a full complement of 12 members. They are:

George Ameyaw, Wendy Walker, Kande Ahmed, Joanne Bernard, Cath Broadway, Deborah Frimpong, Con Lobo, Fade Olorunlambe, Michael Pavis, Cherry Kent, Katie Fish and Marlene Hunter. The group includes homeowners, shared owners and tenants and one member from outside of Thamesmead.

George and Wendy were elected as the chair and vice chair of the group in November. GRG began their role as scrutiny panel in September 2011 and have been looking at Gallions performance across the regulatory standards.

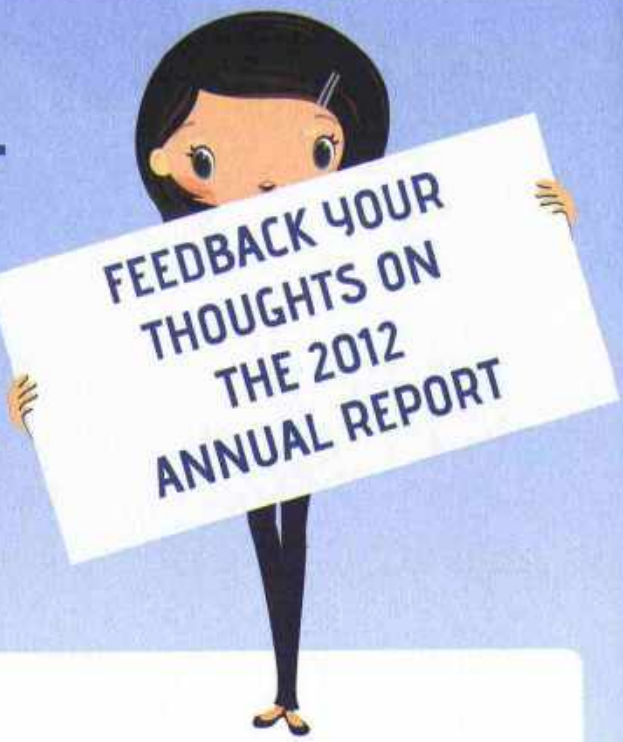
Following GRG scrutiny reports we have:

- Arranged for residents to be involved in agreeing performance targets.
- Our contractors, Axis now wear overshoes when visiting residents properties.
- A leaflet was produced and published with July's issue of Thamesview.
- The telephone message for both Gallions and Axis was changed to make it clear to residents who they should be contacting.
- An article was placed in Thamesview to inform leaseholders that they are able to use Axis repairs service at a charge; comparable to those charged to Gallions.
- English classes have been provided by Axis to their staff.
- Carried out a comprehensive consultation with residents on the local offers that we will offer next year – these are standards that are over and above the regulatory standards, concentrating on what our residents' priorities are.
- Expanded the use of notice boards across Gallions properties.

There are more changes on the way.

In January and February 2013 GRG will be scrutinising how Gallions communicates with homeowners regarding service charges. If you have any comments on this that you would like the GRG to consider please contact Helen Chambers 0208 308 4098 hchambers@gallionsha.co.uk

ANNUAL REPORT FEEDBACK



When you complete the questions and return to us your name will be entered into a draw for a chance to win a free voucher.

1. **Did you find the report was easy to read?**

2. **Did you like the look of the report?**

3. **Did you like the larger format (A4) style?**

4. **Were you intrested in the content?**

. **Other comments**

Please return to Communications Team,
Gallions Housing Association, Freepost RSLT-LYEG-HZAL, PO Box 268, Sidcup, DA15 0FB

YOU SAID... WE DID...



In a recent STAR survey, 29 % of residents found rubbish dumping to be a major problem with a further 41 % stating it was an issue to them.

The removal of dumped rubbish costs Gallions in the region of £200,000 per year and we would rather use this money to bring about improvements in our neighbourhoods.

In July 2012 Gallions employed a Refuse Enforcement Officer, Ernel Cottrell to tackle this problem. His role is to raise residents' awareness of the correct way to dispose of household waste and to take enforcement action against residents who are found to be responsible for rubbish dumping.

Over 400 households were formally warned about their incorrect disposal of household waste and in partnership with Bexley and Greenwich Councils, 17 fixed penalty tickets have been issued, each one requiring the person responsible to pay a fine of £80.

The neighbourhoods targeted have shown a visible improvement and the work will continue with the Enforcement Officer and the Warden Team focussing on areas where this continues to be a problem.

Please ensure you dispose of all waste correctly:

- If you live in a flat or maisonette with a rubbish chute, place the rubbish in a suitable bag and place it in the chute.
- If you live in a house, the local authority provide household waste collection services weekly or fortnightly.
- Place items for recycling in the correct recycle bins and not beside the bins.
- Do not leave any items or bags on the landings of a block or on the street.

If you witness a person incorrectly disposing of household waste or fly tipping, please contact us on 0300 123 1237. Any information will be dealt with and treated confidentially

HOW WELL ARE WE DOING?

This performance chart shows our performance as a landlord during the 2012 financial year compared to 2011. Impressive results from cleaning and inspections for Team Gallions. Team Gallions and our Resident Auditors carry out the internal cleaning inspections and rate sections for all the blocks. They are rated 1-4 points for each section - 1 being the lowest.

	October 2011	October 2012	Service standard	Performance Trend	Current status
Internal Blocks of Thamesmead - Caretakers	86.07%	83.26%	77%	⬅➡	
External Areas of Thamesmead - Street Scene	64.37%	81.32%	77%	⬆	

Once the resident auditors and staff members from Gallions complete their inspection, they take the average score of all the blocks inspected and shows this as a percentage.

The criteria for marking are as follows:

4 = Cleaned to an exemplary / excellent standard. No evidence of grit, mud or grime is present on the survey site.

3 = Cleaned to an acceptable standard. Some grit, mud or grime may be present but only to a minor extent. Most members of the public passing through would not notice it.

2 = In need of thorough cleaning to bring it up to a satisfactory standard. Members of the public passing through would be likely to pass adverse/negative comment on the standard of cleanliness.

1 = Standard of cleanliness is so low it appears cleaning has not taken place for some time. Members of the public passing through the survey site would find it unacceptable.



HAVE YOUR SAY ABOUT OUR REPAIRS, MAINTENANCE & IMPROVEMENTS SERVICE

Our Asset Management Focus Group has now been running for three years. It gives customers the opportunity to have a say in what we plan to invest in repairs, maintenance and improvements to our homes and neighbourhoods in the short, medium and long term.

The group has covered lots of topics and has had an influence over things like window specifications, kitchen standards, repairs publications and has even been on a couple of site visits.

We are looking for more members and would like to hear your views about what your priorities are so we can consider them when deciding what our future strategy will be.

If you are interested in joining the focus group, contact Lesley Edwards on 0300 123 1237 or email ledwards2@gallionsha.co.uk.

RESULTS ARE BACK FROM HOUSEMARK AND IT'S GOOD NEWS!

We received our results from HouseMark at the end of November, and it's good news for Gallions and our residents. We are part of the HouseMark L9 group, which means our performance is scrutinised against eight other housing associations of similar size. Our year on year performance has got better and we have improved performance in overhead costs and our complaints management is the highest in the L9.

2.2%

rent arrears are down by 2.2% from 09/10

21 days

our re-let time is 21 days compared to 35 days in 09/10

74%

satisfaction with neighbourhoods is up 9% to 74%

Our residents will be pleased to know that we ranked number one for the percentage of residents satisfied that their views are being acted upon and that we also ranked number one in value for money for our Resident Engagement activities.

We use HouseMark because it allows us to compare performance and costs with other associations and it identifies where we are doing well and where we need to improve.

So it's good news. We have done well, but the journey to improve performance and manage costs continues.

SWING INTO SEWING

If you've ever wanted to make your own original garments, now's the time to learn.

Thamesmead resident, Cherry Kent will be teaching interested participants how to make dresses on a dressmaking workshop course. It will be happening every second Tuesday from **18.30**, starting 18 December at The Link, Thamesmead (in the cafe). Just bring along your pattern and fabric.

For further information please contact:

Cherry Kent
T: 079303 14525
E: cherrykent@hotmail.co.uk

KNIT 'N' NATTER

You're never too young to learn (or too old) come and join our knitting group. It will be happening every second Wednesday, starting on 12 December from **17:00** to **19:00** at The Link, Thamesmead (in the cafe).
Wool & needles are provided for beginners, or just bring your knitting kit!

For further information contact:

Cherry Kent
T: 079303 14525
E: cherrykent@hotmail.co.uk

HALF TERM BOREDOM BUSTERS RETURNS







Trust Thamesmead is counting down to February half-term and we bet you are too, so why not find out what activities The Link Thamesmead and Sporting Club Thamesmead are offering?

But hurry, their last Boredom Busters activity week, which featured a five day football course, singing, drama and cookery classes, a photography workshop and a day-trip, proved really popular and we expect this one to be too. Look and book now at: www.trust-thamesmead.co.uk



NEW CAFE IN TOWN
THE LINK THAMESMEAD

Thamesmead's brand new youth and community centre, doesn't just offer activities, opportunities and spaces for hire but a café too and with a coffee & cake offer for just £2.50 we can't think of a better place to meet with family and friends.

They also offer yummy soup, a selection of scrumptious sandwiches and a fantastic range of other hot and cold drinks and snacks; all in a fun and welcoming environment. So why not pop on down and support your very own new, local business?

Go on, you know you want to!
www.thelinkthamesmead.co.uk



EVENTS FOR YOUR DIARY

CHINESE NEW YEAR 2013
TRAFALGAR SQUARE, LONDON >> 10 Feb >> 10am-6pm >> Free
www.timeout.com >> 020 7983 4100

THE BOAT RACE 2013
PUTNEY BRIDGE / MORTLAKE, LONDON >> 31 Mar >> 4.30pm >> Free
www.theboatrace.org >> 07702 884 009

LIGHT FROM THE MIDDLE EAST: NEW PHOTOGRAPHY
VICTORIA & ALBERT MUSEUM, LONDON >> Until 7 April >> Free
www.vam.ac.uk >> 020 7942 2000

First class footie facilities

If you are looking for somewhere local to play football or belong to a club and need somewhere to train you won't need to go far from now on if you live in Thamesmead.

That's because the state-of-the-art 3G floodlit pitches that are good enough for the professionals at Sporting Club Thamesmead are now available for hire.

Find out more at: www.sportingclubthamesmead.co.uk



WIN WITH OUR WORDSEARCH

In this wordsearch we have hidden the names of six words associated with Chinese New Year.
Find them all and you could win a £30 shopping voucher.

LANTERN
FIRECRACKERS
RED
LUCK
DRAGON
FAMILY

D	Q	E	W	F	E	G	R	H	T	I	Y	J
U	K	I	G	O	M	F	N	U	O	L	P	W
Q	G	R	H	S	I	A	K	U	L	U	C	K
X	Y	L	Z	V	A	M	B	N	C	M	D	Q
M	E	A	F	J	G	I	H	E	I	T	J	K
K	V	N	A	M	Y	L	S	O	R	P	F	Q
G	R	T	M	J	T	Y	U	L	V	Z	W	X
X	C	E	W	Z	E	A	N	B	M	C	Q	D
D	E	R	F	Y	G	D	R	A	G	O	N	B
I	K	N	L	P	M	T	N	D	O	H	P	G
Q	H	R	K	R	E	D	I	U	Y	V	K	X
C	Y	V	Z	B	A	N	B	M	C	Q	D	W
E	F	I	R	E	C	R	A	C	K	E	R	S

DID YOU KNOW...

Chinese New Year is popularly recognized as the Spring Festival and celebrations last 15 days. Traditionally, married couples give money in certain numbers which reflect good luck to children and unmarried adults in red envelopes. 2013 will be the year of the Snake.

Please return your completed wordsearch and details to: Communications Team, Gallions Housing Association, Freepost RSLT-LYEG-HZAL, PO Box 268, Sidcup, DA15 0FB or drop it into our reception by 22 March 2013. The winner will be selected at random.

Name:

Address:

Telephone:

Email:

CONGRATULATIONS ... to Mary Harrington of Southmere Drive, Abbey Wood who was the winner of our last wordsearch competition.

500 FREE Tickets

Charlton v Bolton

March 30th



Gallions and Axis are celebrating ten years in partnership and want to share the occasion with you, the residents that we serve.

As well as keeping your homes safe and comfortable, we're extremely active in the community. This includes sponsoring Charlton Community Trust's youth social inclusion programme.

We're giving away 500 tickets to a Charlton football match, including coach travel, absolutely free to Gallions residents. First come, first served.

To apply, email footballtickets@gallionsha.co.uk or call 0300 123 1237

10 year Partnership

Gallions Housing Association

axis

KidsView WORDSEARCH

We have hidden the names of six vegetables in this wordsearch. Find them all and you could win an art fun pack!



Q	Z	R	Y	E	W	R	X	T	V	P	J	U
J	T	L	E	E	K	T	Q	M	P	O	I	W
A	N	P	M	B	L	A	K	X	J	T	H	L
I	K	G	I	F	F	E	U	C	A	A	Z	B
T	U	R	N	I	P	Z	D	S	E	T	F	Q
G	L	H	K	I	O	J	C	K	J	O	U	M
D	N	E	O	G	P	N	A	I	R	C	S	T
T	E	U	S	V	R	X	R	Y	Q	Z	M	A
N	B	R	C	K	D	I	R	H	F	U	G	L
H	O	I	P	J	A	K	O	L	F	M	Z	N
H	P	E	A	S	O	P	T	Q	L	R	X	S
U	T	A	U	D	V	G	X	J	Y	L	Z	W
A	C	U	C	U	M	B	E	R	T	F	R	G

POTATO • CARROT • TURNIP

LEEK • PEAS • CUCUMBER

This competition is just for kids under 12. Please return your completed wordsearch and details to: Communications Team, Gallions Housing Association, Freepost RSLT-LYEG-HZAL, PO Box 268, Sidcup, DA15 0FB or drop it into our reception by 22 March 2013. The winner will be selected at random.

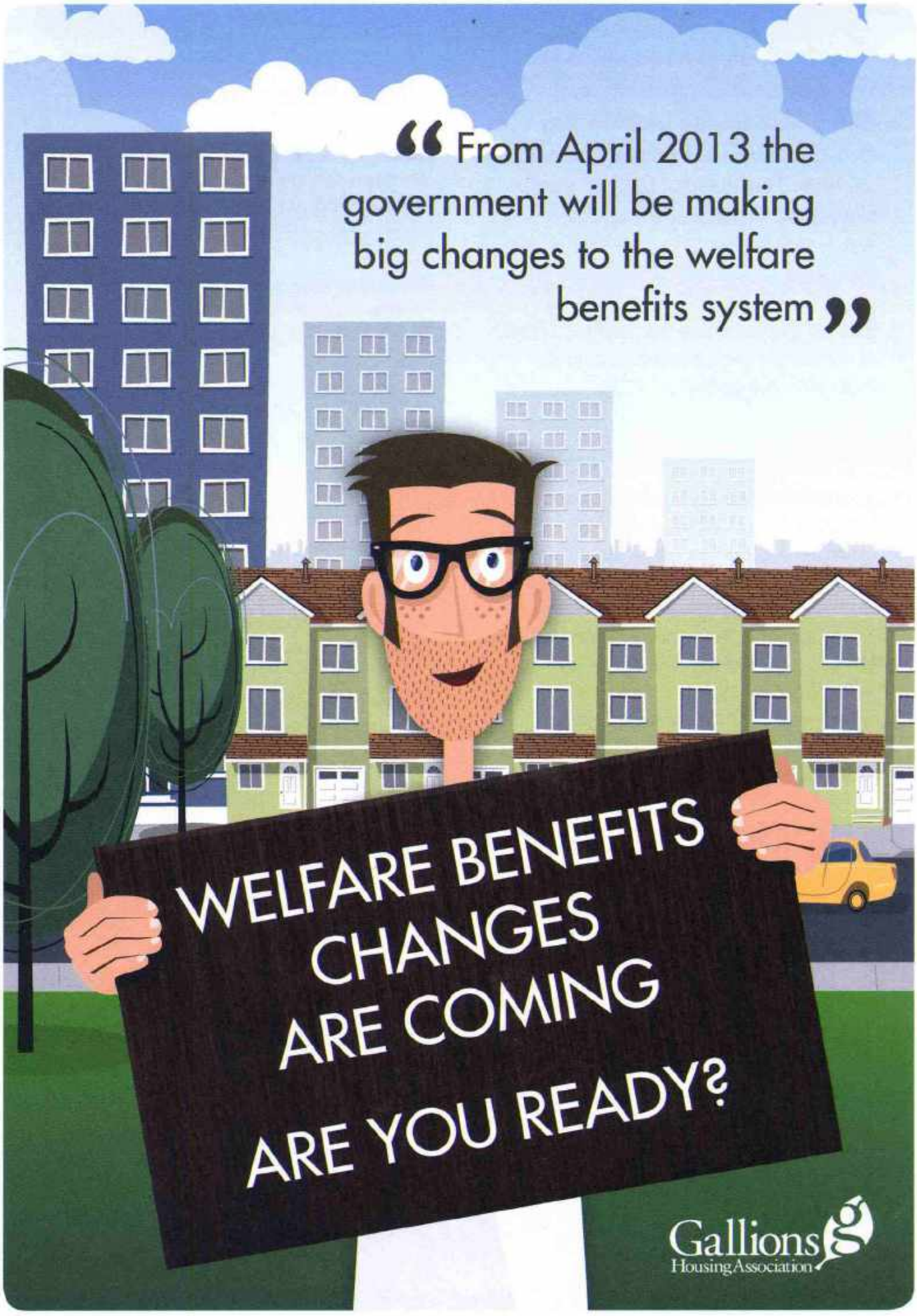
Child's name:

Parent's name:

Address:

Telephone:

WELL DONE ...to Megan Inwood of Merbury Close, Thamesmead who was the winner of our last competition.


“From April 2013 the government will be making big changes to the welfare benefits system”
WELFARE BENEFITS CHANGES ARE COMING
ARE YOU READY?
Gallions
Housing Association

The government has started and will continue making big changes to the welfare benefits system. From April 2013, you may find your benefits:

Capped

So you get no more than either £350 or £500 per week - depending on your circumstances.

Reduced

You will lose some housing benefit (either 14% or 25%) if you have more bedrooms than the government says you need. There are more changes ahead, including the introduction of Personal Independence Payments (which will replace Disability Living Allowance) and Universal Credits, which will be paid direct to you.

What to do now

There is no getting away from it; these changes are going to be major. If you need to find out more, here is a list of some useful advisors/websites:

Gallions Housing Association
Welfare Benefits Team
T: 0300 123 1237

Department for Work and Pensions
T: 0845 605 7064
www.dwp.gov.uk/gov

Direct Gov
www.gov.uk/benefit-cap
www.gov.uk/benefits-adviser

Turn2us
T: 0808 802 2000
www.turn2us.org.uk

Or you can visit us at one of our road shows (see below).

We'll be at the following places in February:

When	Where
Mon 18th Feb, 10am - 4pm	Emmanuel Baptist Church, Yarnton Way, Erith, DA18 4DR
Tue 19th Feb, 10am - 4pm	Outside Gallions' office at 15 Joyce Dawson Way, London, SE28 8RA
Wed 20th Feb, 10am - 4pm	Manor Close Community Centre, 40 Manor Close, Thamesmead, SE28 8EY
Thurs 21st Feb, 10am - 4pm	Broadwater Village Hall 1c Goosander Way, West Thamesmead, SE28 0ER
Fri 22nd Feb, 10am – 4pm	The Link, Belvedere Road, London, SE28